

“Dancing Machaut’s *Chansons baladées*: Unfixed Forms and Mensural Missteps”

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- This is a creative and courageous exploration of dance and meter in the songs of Machaut. While I do not find the current argument persuasive and some elements of the discussion around dance inaccurate and anachronistic, I believe substantial rewriting to focus on meter would result in a solid contribution to Machaut studies. The article as a whole is quite long; as I detail below, I recommend reframing the article to focus on regular/irregular metrical groupings in Machaut’s songs and removing the dance framing. This should shorten the article extensively and allow for a more concise structure. Subheadings throughout would be very helpful for readers, alongside more signposting in the writing. As the author will see, I am highly critical of the dance-historical and dance-analytical aspects of their article; I do not mean to be discouraging, but I do want to make sure the author is aware of the potential issues before their work goes to a wider audience so they have a chance to re-think the arguments. This will be my primary focus in comments below; I generally accept the analyses where they do not depend on dance but could be read as music-theoretical readings alone.
- Broadly, more engagement with Machaut studies and manuscript studies would be helpful throughout; I indicate some specific points below. By contrast, there is a certain reliance on some scholarship that I would strongly caution against (primarily Mullally, see below).
- Title: not sure I understand what an unfixed form is; I understand it is a play with *formes fixes*, but what does that mean in terms of an unfixed form? It’s never addressed in the article (neither fixed nor unfixed forms)
- P1 FN 1 is a mix of citations to provide overviews of medieval dance; it seems to be missing recent scholarship on dance (for instance, Dickason’s 2021 book)
- P1 The reference to the *carole* is problematic since the sole citation is to Mullally and the footnote (FN2) does not refer to any other scholarship on the *carole*; only FN 3 includes one further, which is Greene’s now outdated 1977 book on English carols which, while including a broader introduction, does not reflect a collection of *carole*’s in the sense of the French dance being referred to in the article. More problematically is using Mullally’s 2011 book as evidence here and elsewhere. While his book collates many useful references, his conclusions have been largely rejected by dance and music scholars; see, for instance, Timothy McGee’s measured yet highly critical review here: <https://doi.org/10.1093/ml/gcs050>. Simply put, while Mullally may be cited for the wealth of materials amassed, his conclusions regarding music and dance steps cannot be the basis of future arguments. One of the criticisms of Mullally is that he does not distinguish between the idea of dance (such as that conveyed in metaphorical terms in *romances*) and lived, practiced dance (the actual dances performed by people in the Middle Ages). The conflation of metaphor with reality is not a new issue for dance studies, but one that needs to be guarded against carefully.
- P1 A major concern related to the previous point is articulated on P1 where the author states the following: “From these kinds of evidence, modern scholars have reconstructed the basic

movement of the fourteenth-century carole. What remains is to attempt matching those dance steps to music we know to have been danced and, in turn, to speculate about how the structure of dance music may have encoded dance conventions.” This is really tricky! First, who are the modern scholars? If this reference is to Mullally alone, then this invalidates this conclusion. While the “basic movements” might indeed be simply steps to the right/left, forward/back (which is a logical conclusion based solely on images), there are no dance manuals or any other texts that are not metaphorical or fictional that can be used to prove this from the Middle Ages, and from the fourteenth century in particular. This obviously creates issues for the next statement, which suggests the possibility of connecting dance steps to musical works that were danced to. The problem, though, which Lawrence Earp, Ardis Butterfield, Jennifer Saltzstein, and others have articulated clearly, is that we don’t always know which works were danced to and which were dance-inflected works (akin, for instance, to waltzes included in major orchestral works; see the work of Ziolkowski on dance topoi, Wye J. Allanbrook, and others). The two pillars of the article, then, the dance steps and the dance music are both problematic from the get-go, and making an argument that reads one against the other relies on layers of assumptions and hypotheses.

- P2 proposes using “dance step notation” (not entirely sure what this is since dance notation does not survive from this time in the modern sense) as an analytical tool to analyze Machaut’s notated works (presumably ones associated terminologically with dance) and specifically metrical groupings. Setting aside the problem of defining something like a “dance step notation” when we have no contemporary (i.e. medieval) dance notation nor do we have manuals or really many clear, non-metaphorical, non-fictional references to dance at all, let alone the *carole*, I don’t quite understand why one needs a new analytical tool to study metrical groupings in Machaut’s music. Analysis of Machaut’s music has a lengthy history in music studies and music theory and an argument about metrical groupings or meter in general might be better off rooted in existing studies (like Maw’s, which the author cites later) in order to suggest new insights instead of attempting a connection to dance that cannot be proven and has no basis in medieval sources.
- P4 The definition of the *carole* arrived at is quite problematic since it is essentially summarizing Mullally’s already rejected scholarship and relies on 1) a biblical text and 2) a sermon text. Neither of these can be taken as evidence of lived dance practice without far more corroborating evidence. The author in FN 6 does state that the actual form of the dance (circular, linear) does not have a bearing on the argument, which is good since debates continue around whether the *carole* is circular or linear, but this ambiguity extends also to the steps themselves. Moreover, while the author notes that many songs accompanying dance have refrains (although this is not entirely clear, as Jennifer Saltzstein’s work makes clear), they state that the refrain was sung by a choir of dancers and the verses by soloists—but this is all conjecture. There is no manuscript evidence to suggest that refrains were the domain of choral groups (indeed, in French sources where refrains are interpolated, including in dance scenes (!), the refrains are often voices in the narrative by single characters); see Saltzstein again and also Caldwell on the performance of refrains in Latin contexts, and also in FN 8 where the author does not state that refrains and verses could be sung by soloists. It’s also conjecture to state that the dancers were themselves the singers; while there is some evidence for this (again in literary sources), there is no manuscript evidence.
- P5 I can’t understand the sentence beginning “That singers and dancers...”

- P5 The author states that “The close connection between music and dance is immediately apparent in the natural fit between binary dance steps, alternating left and right, and music in binary mensuration, imperfect tempus.” While this does make sense, how do we know this is how composers, musicians, and dancers were thinking in the Middle Ages? And what about the popularity of ternary meters for dance music in later periods? Or the dotted rhythms in notated instrumental dance music (see, for instance, the editions of McGee 1989)? Then, as now, there are many ways for dancers to dance to music, and a binary rhythm is only one possibility and I would argue is not inherently better for dancing than a ternary meter. Finally, no medieval theorist connects dance music to a specific meter to my knowledge, only to specific poetic forms (and then potentially in a metaphorical or anagogical sense).
- P5 What does “sophisticated” mean here? It feels like a value judgement; better to define to avoid that sense.
- P5 I am confused about the jump from binary rhythms to *ars nova* mensural notation/rhythms. While I find this suggestion intriguing, namely that “dancers [were] responding to certain types of metrical flexibility and ambiguity made possible through *ars nova* mensural innovation,” I just don’t know how you could prove that through musical analysis alone since we have no evidence of how dancers’ interacted with any music, let alone with Machaut’s compositions. Equally, while this is a compelling question: “how can dance interpret a stream of pulses that are weighted unequally by the feet and grouped irregularly in a variety of musical ways?”, I am unsure as to how one goes about answering this again without knowing anything about how dancers’ perceived the music (or even if Machaut’s music was ever danced to at all, or whether Earp’s “aesthetic ennoblement” means it only “remembers” dance as a *topoi* and was not musical accompaniment for any kind of formal or informal choreography).
- P6 The author suggests that we can learn something through this analysis that cannot be seen in the manuscript (yet aren’t we seeing it through the *ars nova* notation?) nor can it be felt in modern performances; this, too, is compelling, but unclear how that will come about. Also, and this is just out of curiosity, if it’s not something in the manuscript, and we can’t feel it somehow in performance, then is it helpful to know about it?
- P6 “simple dance song from thirteenth-century France” How is this determined? The author then turns to Machaut’s “danced songs” which derives from Machaut’s authorial inscriptions; I wonder about taking Machaut’s word as fact and not as literary embellishment, ornamentation, etc., since these are manuscripts in general (and would be good to see a more thorough examination of which manuscripts include which dance-focused inscriptions) authorial artifices—carefully planned presentation copies that must be treated as artistic objects and not necessarily reflections of lived practices. Also, taking contemporary poetry treatises into consideration is important here in terms of how a poet like Machaut might refer to songs as “dance songs”. There are generic conventions when it comes to form etc. that do not necessarily connect to function; genre does not equal function.
- P7 The discussion of Grocheio needs to be clearer to show how the *virelai* is connected to the *ductio*; how does this treatise “reveal the *ductia* (per se) to be the ancestor of *virelai* form danced in *carole* in late thirteenth-century France”? Citations to McGee are logically, but for

this argument to succeed I think we need to have evidence cited here in terms of poetic and musical form.

- P8 This example points to some of the concerns cited above about the context for “dance songs” in thirteenth-century France, namely as narrative interpolations. This is the case here with the refrain vdB 1797, which is designated as the accompaniment to a carole in *Renart le Nouvel* sung by Renart (the fox, and also a soloist, in relation to the above comments concerning the performance of refrains/caroles by choral groups or dancers). There is not enough evidence here to suggest this refrain (not carole per se) was actually a dance song functionally; this is very much a literary reference and musical interpolation that serves a narrative function. This is also a unicum, meaning the refrain does not survive elsewhere to suggest it was part of a larger dance-song repertoire, and not simply a creation of the author/scribe intended to musically elaborate this festive scene in the romance. Note also the highly valuable resources for refrains: <https://www.refrain.ac.uk/refrains/view/1797>
- P9 The author writes “The fourteenth-century *carole* need not be any more complicated.” I wonder about this; can we ever really assume continuity across centuries like this? The example provided here is also from a narrative, the *Roman d’Alexandre*.
- P10 Small note, but this sentence needs to be edited: “The melody again tumbles downwards in each of two parallel phrases, essentially arpeggiating through a triad.”
- P11 and fn 19 This is the major problem I have trouble moving past, as will many readers: the proposal of dance notation, for which fn 19 states the following: “Inspiration for this simple dance notation was taken from Little 1975.” This short article does not provide a firm foundation for the analysis provided here, given that the notation is from ca. 1700 and from an entirely different musical, social, and choreographic context. While inspiration is of course fine to draw from whatever, the analysis that follows does more than draw inspiration, it applies dance steps (really choreography, a term the author does not use) anachronistically, without contemporary support for doing so. The argument and analysis simply does not work and, more importantly, could lead other scholars to believe that dance steps can be recovered for this repertoire in this way, and that is simply not the case. The danger here is that which Joan Rimmer discovered in her work (Rimmer, Joan. “Carole, Rondeau and Branle in Ireland 1300-1800: Part 1 The Walling of New Ross and Dance Texts in the Red Book of Ossory.” *Dance Research: The Journal of the Society for Dance Research* 7, no. 1 (1989): 20-46”) which has been roundly dismissed. I really don’t want this author to be exposed to the degree of criticism that they will be if this is published as is. (Side note, Joan Rimmer has in fact published a questionable piece that I’m surprised to not see cited here: Rimmer, Joan. “Dance Elements in Trouvère Repertory.” *Dance Research: The Journal of the Society for Dance Research* 3, no. 2 (1985): 23-34. Rimmer, in fact, attempts similar kinds of work to this author, which never became accepted because it was found to not be based in evidence but instead conjecture.) These comments and concerns apply to the remainder of the article and the analyses therein.
- P12 The author moves here to Machaut and his manuscripts; as I note above, it would be good to have more context for his manuscripts, their order, their contents, etc., as a foundation here. Also, this is another moment where music (and image) is interpolated into a narrative. This context for thirteenth- and fourteenth-century song needs to be more carefully examined for what it means for the music; there is a lot of scholarship on this in Machaut studies, which I

do not see in the footnotes. I would also caution in a general sense that, in a narrative, the presence of an image of dancers should be taken with a grain of salt, just as should the music and its function.

- P16 This is where the author introduces what I think could be the core of a revised version of this article, namely meter. Instead of the framing around dance, which opens the author up to severe criticism, I highly recommend focusing in on the question of meter and rhythm in Machaut's songs. This would allow the author to retain most of their analyses while making a more convincing and compelling argument about meter in relation to ars nova notation. This then connects with many current strands of scholarship on Machaut and avoids the pitfalls of hypothetical and conjectural discussions of dance. If the author would like to retain a reference to dance, this could perhaps happen in the conclusion and be framed purely as an intriguing hypothetical. For instance, this line could be the central thread of a revised article "Following David Maw's extensive work on meter in Machaut's songs, I identify the sense of medieval meter as a combination of motivic initiation and termination, rhythmic grouping (especially recurrent), agogic accent, text alignment, simultaneous articulations, contrapuntal resolution, and harmonic change." The trick will be to differentiate the arguments here from Maw's.
- P17 I don't understand this sentence as written: "The way that alternation of left/right feet in dance parses mensural groupings into strong/weak maps onto the hierarchical organization of medieval French mensural theory insofar as any subdivision will have its first attack accented by simultaneity with its parent duration."
- P21 "Multimedia performance—combining lyric poetry, song, and dance—allows for higher level meanings to emerge as one medium comments upon the other." This is absolutely right! And other scholars have made this argument, I would love to see their work consulted and cited here, and for this multimedia character to be more fully engaged with.
- P26 I don't understand this: "Opening rests were crucial not only for mensural reckoning but for performance insofar as they marked time so that the dance may start conventionally on a strong left foot before singing commenced on a weak right"
- P27 The reference to Lydgate seems a little far from the repertoire and themes at hand perhaps?
- P27-28 Drawing on Chaganti's work makes sense, but her argument really is about something other than lived practices, which is what the author is trying to argue, so I'm not sure this is convincing. In fact, Chaganti's points (and Peraino's, and Butterfield's, and others) is that French lyric embodies dance, but doesn't necessarily accompany it functionally—which is the opposite of what the author is attempting to show through analysis (that music responds in some way to the needs of dancers)
- P54 The author writes that "This study does not presume to answer how Machaut's songs were danced, only to grapple with some questions that arise when pairing regular dance steps with irregular musical groupings." Instead of dance, could the author not construct the argument around regular and irregular metrical patterns? Dance does not need to be a referent here.